

Explicit Meaning - Study Guide

Find what the text actually says before you infer anything.

What this skill is

Explicit meaning is information the author states directly. You do not need to guess the author's intention, combine distant clues, or read between the lines. Your job is to locate the exact fact, action, condition, reason, or detail that answers the question.

Explicit vs. inferred

Explicit: The notice says the office closes at 4:30 p.m. Therefore, 4:30 p.m. is directly stated.

Inferred: The notice says the lights were off and the doors were locked at 4:45 p.m. You may infer the office was closed, but that conclusion is not stated in those exact words.

How exam-style questions ask it

- According to the passage, which statement is true?
- Which statement is directly supported by the passage?
- What does the passage state about ___?
- According to the notice, when / where / why / how does ___ happen?

The 3-step method

- 1. Identify the target. Is the question asking about a time, person, rule, reason, action, result, or condition?**
- 2. Locate the matching sentence. Find the part of the passage that discusses that exact target.**
- 3. Verify every word. Choose the option that keeps the same meaning without adding, removing, or changing a condition.**

Watch the qualifier words

Many explicit-meaning questions become difficult because one small word changes the rule. Pay special attention to these:

- above / below / at least / no more than
- before / after / during / beginning on
- some / most / all / only
- may / must / should / can
- except / unless / if / when

Example

Text: "Orders above \$50 qualify for free delivery."

Supported: A \$51 order qualifies for free delivery.

Not supported: A \$50 order qualifies for free delivery. The text says above \$50, not \$50 or more.

Common wrong-answer traps

True elsewhere

The option repeats a real detail from the passage, but it answers a different question.

Reasonable inference

The option could be true, but the author never directly states it.

Changed condition

The option changes a time, amount, group, sequence, or exception.

Overstatement

The passage says some or may, but the option says all or always.

Contradiction

The option conflicts with a directly stated detail.

Worked example

Passage: The library will close its second-floor study room from March 4 through March 8 while new lighting is installed. The first-floor reading room and computer area will remain open during regular hours.

Question: Which statement is directly supported by the passage?

- A. The entire library will close for five days.
- B. The second-floor study room will be unavailable from March 4 through March 8.

- C. New computers will be installed on the first floor.
- D. The reading room will close earlier than usual.

Answer: B. The passage directly gives both the location and the dates. A changes one room into the entire library. C invents a computer installation. D contradicts the statement that regular hours remain in effect.

Mini check

Text: Volunteers may pick up garden tools from the community shed after 8:00 a.m. on Saturdays. Tools must be returned by 6:00 p.m. the same day.

1. What is the earliest stated pickup time on Saturday?

- A. 6:00 a.m.
- B. 8:00 a.m.
- C. 6:00 p.m.
- D. Any time before noon

2. Which statement is directly supported?

- A. Tools may be kept overnight.
- B. Only volunteers may return tools.
- C. Tools must be returned the same day.
- D. The shed closes at 6:00 p.m.

Answers: 1-B, 2-C.

Quick rule

If you have to add an unstated idea to make an option work, it is not an explicit-meaning answer.